

Asus Chromebook CM32 Detachable

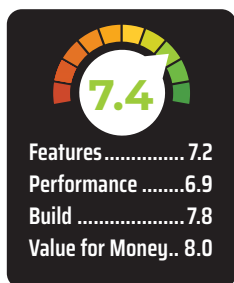
A surprisingly good laptop-tablet hybrid with one big catch

I have used plenty of compact laptops over the years, but the Asus Chromebook CM32 with a detachable keyboard gave me a whole new perspective on what I actually need from a computer. For sure, this machine does not try to be a more affordable MacBook or a Windows laptop with fewer features. Instead, it slots in right between a tablet and a conventional laptop, with ChromeOS doing most of the heavy lifting. I carried it around in my backpack, used it for writing, browsing, video calls, watching YouTube, and reading documents, and spent plenty of time using it as a tablet, i.e., without the keyboard attached. My take — there are a few compromises with the Asus Chromebook CM32, but the price makes those compromises harder to ignore. Here's my full review.

MORE TABLET THAN LAPTOP

The first thing I noticed about the Asus Chromebook CM32 is how easy it is to carry. The tablet itself weighs roughly 640 grams, depending on the configuration, and that makes a huge difference when you are used to carrying a 1.3kg or 1.5kg laptop around all day. Add the keyboard and stand cover, and you still have a machine that's much easier to throw into a backpack than a laptop.

As the subhead goes, I kept finding myself treating it like a tablet first and a laptop second. And this is not necessarily a criticism. In fact, I think this is the CM32's biggest appeal. Detach the



keyboard, and you have a reasonably large 12.1-inch tablet that is comfortable for reading, watching videos, or going through documents. Attach it again, and ChromeOS gives you a familiar desktop interface.

That said, the stand cover is less impressive.

Getting the kickstand open is not as effortless as I would like. It can feel stiff, and when I first used it, I occasionally ended up pulling the cover away instead of opening the stand. Once you figure out where to press, it gets easier. On a desk, though, it works well.

The other problem is connectivity. You get one USB-C port, and the headphone jack. That USB-C port handles charging and other functions, so anyone planning to connect a mouse, or display while charging will probably need a hub.

There is also no fingerprint scanner. Unlocking the device means relying on a PIN or password, although ChromeOS offers other convenient ways to interact with a connected Android phone.

DISPLAY IS THE STAR

The display is easily my favourite part of the Asus Chromebook CM32. It is a 12.1-inch IPS touchscreen with a 2,560 x 1,600-pixel resolution, a 16:10 aspect ratio, and up to 600 nits of brightness. It also supports a 120Hz refresh rate and covers up to 98 per cent of the DCI-P3 colour gamut. There is Gorilla Glass protection and an anti-fingerprint coating as well.

In daily use, all the aforementioned specs make a lot of sense. Text looks exceptionally sharp. Websites are easy to read. Google Docs gives you plenty of vertical space, and that 16:10 ratio is particularly useful when you are working through long documents or PDFs. I would much rather read a lengthy article on this screen than on a smaller 11-inch tablet.

The 120Hz refresh rate is another nice touch. Scrolling through menus, webpages, or simply through the UI feels noticeably smoother, and the difference is especially obvious when you jump between this and a conventional 60Hz budget laptop. It also makes the CM32 feel more like a premium tablet.

I would not say the screen is on the same level as the best OLED panels on flagship tablets or phones such as the Galaxy S26 Ultra. You do not get those deep blacks or the contrast that makes OLED content pop. But for a Chromebook, this is a very good panel.

The 600-nit brightness also helps when you are sitting somewhere bright. I still prefer avoiding direct sunlight, but the screen does not immediately become difficult to see when you move away from an indoor desk.

KEYBOARD AND STYLUS

Detachable keyboards are often where otherwise good tablet-laptop hybrids fall apart. The Asus Chromebook CM32 avoids that problem. The keyboard has 1.35mm of key travel, and I found it much more comfortable than I expected. It does not feel like one of those ultra-thin covers where every key-